Voices from the Lowell Mills

Writings of Lowell mill workers · The Lowell Offering, 1844

Source: The Lowell Offering (1844) and Mind Amongst the Spindles (1844 anthology of Lowell Offering writing, Project Gutenberg #37471). Public domain. Non-contiguous passages are separated by [. . .]; shorter cuts inside a passage are marked with an ellipsis (. . .).

> Two pieces written by Lowell mill workers themselves in 1844: a dialogue in which 'Miss B' defends factory work against the charge that it is degrading and 'savors of slavery,' and a story in which 'Ellen' voices the workers' complaints about the bells, the pace, and the hours before being talked into staying. The Offering was company-friendly, so read for what is defended as well as what is complained of.

‘The ‘Utopian’ Lowell Looms’ — a dialogue from The Lowell Offering (1844)

A dialogue from the Lowell Offering (1844)

Miss S: I am very happy to see you this evening, Miss Bartlett, for I have something particular to say to you. Now do tell me if you still persist in your resolution to return to your factory employment? . . . Miss B: By whom is factory labor considered degrading? It is by those who believe all labor degrading—by those who contemptuously speak of the farmer, the mechanic, the printer, the seamstress, and all who are obliged to toil as belonging to the lower orders—by those who seem to think the condition of labor excludes all the capacities of the mind and the virtues of humanity. . . . Miss S: There are objections to factory labor, which serve to render it degrading—objections which cannot be urged against any other kind of female employment. For instance, to be called and to be dismissed by the ringing of a bell savors of compulsion and slavery, and cannot cease to produce mortification without having been destructive to self-respect.

Miss B: In almost all kinds of employment it is necessary to keep regular established hours: more particularly so where there are so many connected as in the factories. Because we are reminded of those hours by the ringing of a bell, it is no argument against our employment, any more than it would be against going to church or to school. . . . Miss S: You will not acknowledge that factory labor is degrading, or that it is productive of vice, but you must own that it fosters ignorance. When there are so many hours out of each day devoted to labor, there can be no time for study and improvement.

Miss B: It is true that too large a portion of our time is confined to labor. But, first, let me remark that this is an objection which cannot be said to exist only in factory labor. . . . A factory girl’s work is neither hard nor complicated. She can go on with perfect regularity in her duties while her mind may be actively employed on any other subject. There can be no better place for reflection, when there must be toil, than the factory. The patronage which newspapers and periodicals find in our city, our well-worn libraries, evening schools, crowded churches and sabbath schools, prove that factory operatives find leisure to use the means of improvement both in mind and heart.

From Mind Amongst the Spindles (1844)

“The Spirit of Discontent” (Lowell Offering, by “Almira”)

“I will not stay in Lowell any longer; I am determined to give my notice this very day,” said Ellen Collins, as the earliest bell was tolling to remind us of the hour for labor. . . . “I am going home, where I shall not be obliged to rise so early in the morning, nor be dragged about by the ringing of a bell, nor confined in a close noisy room from morning till night. I will not stay here; I am determined to go home in a fortnight.” . . . “And so, Ellen,” said I, “you think it unpleasant to rise so early in the morning, and be confined in the noisy mill so many hours during the day. And I think so, too. All this, and much more, is very annoying, no doubt. But we must not forget that there are advantages, as well as disadvantages, in this employment, as in every other. If we expect to find all sunshine and flowers in any station in life, we shall most surely be disappointed. . . . A person has only to be honest, industrious, and moral, to secure the respect of the virtuous and good, though he may not be worth a dollar; while on the other hand, an immoral person, though he should possess wealth, is not respected.”

On the bells and the hours of labor

"As to the morality of the place," returned Ellen, "I have no fault to find. I object to the constant hurry of everything. We cannot have time to eat, drink, or sleep; we have only thirty minutes, or at most three-quarters of an hour, allowed us, to go from our work, partake of our food, and return to the noisy chatter of machinery. Up before day, at the clang of the bell—and out of the mill by the clang of the bell—into the mill, and at work, in obedience to that ding-dong of a bell—just as though we were so many living machines. I will give my notice to-morrow: go, I will—I won't stay here and be a white slave." . . . Ellen's hearty laugh interrupted my description—and presently we proceeded, very pleasantly, to compare a country life with a factory life in Lowell. Her scowl of discontent had departed, and she was prepared to consider the subject candidly. We agreed, that since we must work for a living, the mill, all things considered, is the most pleasant, and best calculated to promote our welfare; that we will work diligently during the hours of labor; improve our leisure to the best advantage, in the cultivation of the mind,—hoping thereby not only to increase our own pleasure, but also to add to the happiness of those around us.

Words to know

degrading — lowering a person's dignity or social standing

lower orders — the working classes, seen as socially beneath others

savors of — has the feel or flavor of

mortification — deep shame or humiliation

operatives — mill workers who ran the machines

fortnight — two weeks

white slave — a free white worker treated like a slave by harsh factory discipline